

Narrowing Lightning AI to its infrastructure delivery lead

Account entry plan for Spencer Refer | Prepared Thursday, October 1, 2026 | Sources: HubSpot, Lemlist, ZoomInfo, Apollo

15 Lightning leads in Wave C	1 Chicago-area contact (847)	Sep 24 new CFO, CMO, CPO announced	0 replies
STAGE Wave C prospect. No deal.	RUNNING NOW CTF ABM - Lightning AI (Wave C), 15 leads	LAST TOUCH Sep 30: email 1 to Sep 28 adds; call tasks to CPTO and VP Eng ignored	NEXT STEP Mon Oct 5: email Gina Barrios (Director, Infrastructure Delivery)

Bottom line

Lightning AI (the PyTorch Lightning company) now runs its own AI cloud and data center operations: Apollo and Lemlist show a dozen data center operations leads and site managers. It just named a new CFO, CMO and CPO (Sep 24), and is hiring a Senior PM for AI Infrastructure. Your list grew to 15 people on Sep 28. Two details point the way: **Gina Barrios, Director of Infrastructure Delivery**, owns getting capacity live, and **Thomas Rhee, Data Center Operations Manager, has an 847 (Chicago suburbs) number**. The plan trims the list and asks Rhee whether Lightning operates a site near Chicago.

What Lightning is, in one analogy

Lightning started as a recipe book for AI developers and has opened its own restaurants: GPU clusters it runs itself. New restaurants need supply routes, and the infrastructure delivery team picks them.

Signals worth citing

Signal	Source	So what for the opener
Executive team expanded: Heather Paduck CFO, Betty Junod CMO, Jarlath Doherty CPO (Sep 24)	ZoomInfo news	Scaling the business side; spend discipline incoming.
Hiring Senior Product Manager, AI Infrastructure (Sep 25) and Senior Infrastructure Software Engineer (Sep 2)	ZoomInfo scoops	Infrastructure is a priority.
Peter Bershatsky (ex-AWS, Confluent) named VP Strategy and Partnerships (Jul 1)	ZoomInfo news	Partner ecosystem build. Possible channel angle.
Thomas Rhee, DC Operations Manager, 847 area code	Lemlist	Possible Chicago-area site.

Work already in motion

When	Channel / campaign	What happened	Read
Sep 11-28	Wave C, 3 emails	To Saurabh Giri (CPTO), Noha Alon (VP Eng); 2 emails to Patrick Palmieri, Alexei Ghiuritan	No replies
Sep 16	Wave C	Steps skipped for bounced addresses	-
Sep 28-30	Wave C, 11 new leads	DC ops leads, managers, network engineers; email 1	List too wide
Sep 30	Call tasks	Giri and Alon call tasks ignored	-

Who to reach, in order

Contact	Title (source)	Where	Why they matter	Status / email
Gina Barrios	Director, Infrastructure Delivery (HubSpot)	Colorado (720)	Owens bringing capacity online.	Email 1 Sep 30
Thomas Rhee	Data Center Operations Manager (HubSpot)	Chicago suburbs (847)	Possible local site.	Added Sep 28; step skipped
Patrick Palmieri	Principal Network Engineer (HubSpot)	New Jersey (973)	Network design.	Wave C, 2 emails; post liked
Ariel Ma.	Director of Operations (Apollo)	n/a	Operations owner.	Not contacted
Saurabh Giri	Chief Product & Technology Officer (HubSpot)	n/a	Executive. Hold.	3 emails, call ignored

Not worth chasing for this goal

Remove the DC operations leads and technicians added Sep 28 (Conner, Samarkandi, Stewart, Acevedo, Moreno, Weaver, Minin) from the sequence.

How the access path should run



Messages, by contact

1. Thomas Rhee Data Center Operations Manager

Why them: Chicago-area number.

Channel: Email Mon Oct 5 (pause his Wave C step) | Subject: Lightning near Chicago?

Thomas, I noticed your number is a Chicago-area one. Does Lightning run a site in the Chicago market? I own underground fiber there and would like to know whether there's anything worth talking about.

2. Gina Barrios Director, Infrastructure Delivery

Why them: Owns delivery.

Channel: Email Wed Oct 7 | Subject: Fiber for the next Lightning site

Gina, when Lightning brings a new cluster online, who chooses the fiber between sites: your team or the colo provider? If it's you, I'd like Crosstown to be a known option in Chicago. Happy to send our map.

The plan

When	Move	Notes
Fri Oct 2	Trim Wave C to Barrios, Rhee, Palmieri, Ghiuritan, Giri.	-
Mon Oct 5	Email Thomas Rhee.	-
Wed Oct 7	Email Gina Barrios.	-
Week of Oct 19	If a Chicago site exists, send the KMZ to Barrios and Palmieri.	-
Oct 30	Qualify in or out.	-

What progress looks like (for management)

By	Milestone	How we will know
Oct 16	Know whether Lightning has a Chicago-area site	HubSpot note

Guardrails

- Credits used: ZoomInfo company and signals for 1 company; 1 Apollo search.

Sources

Lemlist 'CTF ABM - Lightning AI (Wave C)'; HubSpot contacts; ZoomInfo news (Jun 8, Jul 1, Sep 24, 2026) and scoops (Sep 2-25); Apollo people search (Oct 1, 2026).